INDIA TODAY GROUP

durex The Birds and Bees talk

CONSENT CULTURE

gdb GROSS DOMESTIC BEHAVIOUR

FIRST EVER REPORT

AWARENESS | EQUITY | PROTECTION
CONSENT | INCLUSION

SEX & CONSENT

A SURVEY THAT MAPS THE CHALLENGES WOMEN FACE FROM PARTNERS, FAMILY AND THE WIDER SOCIETY WHEN THEY SAY 'NO'

By **KAUSHIK DEKA** | *Illustration by* **NILANJAN DAS**/ AI

Every day, in millions of Indian homes, a quiet transaction takes place. A woman wants to say 'no'—to a demand, a touch, an expectation—and calculates what it will cost her. Will it be heard as a boundary or as an insult? Will she have to explain it, soften it, apologise for it? Or is it simpler to just go along? Consent, at its core, is the answer to a single question: does a woman's 'no' count?

The question matters because consent is the smallest unit of freedom. Before a woman can claim equality in the Constitution, the workplace or the marriage bed, she must be able to refuse without fear, and to change her mind without punishment. India has debated consent loudly in recent years: in courtrooms weighing marital rape, in newsrooms after #MeToo, in films, classrooms and family WhatsApp groups. The word has entered the national vocabulary. What nobody has measured, until now, is whether it has entered the national conversation.

That is what the India Today Group set out to do. Its consent survey, the first of its kind in the country, asked 5,000 adult women across every region, income group, education level, religion, employment category, marital status and social group to map the distance between what they believe about consent and what actually happens when they exercise it.

The survey questions were framed under four heads: consent, choice and the limits of love; the private sphere of family, marriage and control; unsafe worlds spanning public, professional and digital violations; and the building of a consent culture through education, law and accountability. The responses reveal how Indian women negotiate the simple act of saying 'no' to partners, elders, bosses, strangers and screens.

The good news first. Nearly four in five women—across class, region and generation—agree that 'no means no' under all circumstances, without exception. What they do not have is the social permission to act on it.

Only about 36 per cent of women clearly say that consent given under pressure is not consent. The rest treat pressured agreement as consent in some form. The right to change one's mind splits the sample down the middle: